

Yechiel Kalmenson

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Senior Backend Engineer, published author, and technical speaker with 6+ years of polyglot experience (Go, Kotlin, Ruby, Python) specializing in distributed systems, API design, Developer Experience (DX), and Open Source Software (OSS) community engagement.. Drawing on a unique background in pedagogy and developer support, I excel at building highly reliable, scalable backend services that power seamless developer workflows and accelerate time-to-value. A champion of Extreme Programming (XP) and observability, I am dedicated to building flexible systems that balance speed, experimentation, and long-term maintainability. A passionate programmer and writer, I actively maintain a technical blog and have delivered talks at major conferences like KubeCon and RubyConf on engineering ethics and developer mentorship.

EMPLOYMENT HISTORY

Rise8 | Senior Software Engineer | April 2025 - Present

- **AI-Augmented Engineering:** Accelerate development velocity on a critical satellite resource allocation system by integrating AI tools (Claude) into the daily workflow. Model and teach responsible AI usage to the team, demonstrating how to use LLMs to augment architectural decision-making without bypassing core engineering principles.
- **Hands-on Mentorship & Quality:** Embed directly with engineering squads to identify technical debt and design limitations. Led pair-programming sessions and interactive code reviews to mentor peers on modernizing legacy components while maintaining strict GovTech compliance and data integrity standards.

Broadcom - VMware - Pivotal Software | Software Engineer | November 2018 - September 2024

- **Open Source Contributor & Architect:** Spearheaded the effort to port Envoy Proxy to Windows to support internal infrastructure needs. Actively navigated CNCF project governance, breaking down complex PRs into manageable chunks, and collaborating directly with core maintainers from Microsoft, Google, and Lyft to align on architectural consistency and secure successful feature merges.
- **XP Mentorship & Technical Leadership:** Championed Extreme Programming (XP) practices across distributed systems teams, utilizing daily pair programming as a hands-on mentorship tool. Guided junior engineers through complex problem-solving by verbalizing architectural decisions and debugging strategies in real-time, fostering a culture of shared knowledge and high code quality.
- **Polyglot Development & Education:** Built high-availability distributed services for Tanzu and Cloud Foundry across Go, Kotlin, Python, and others, demonstrating the ability to mentor engineers across different language paradigms and complex infrastructure topics.
- **Security Program Design:** Led the development of Davos, a custom internal CVE tracking application integrated with external scanners (Black Duck, Trivy), teaching the team to treat security vulnerabilities as first-class citizens in the development lifecycle.

Newtek Business Services | Full-Stack Developer | January 2018 - November 2018

- Maintained legacy PHP applications, triaged bug reports, and remediated critical security vulnerabilities

Flatiron School | Technical Coach | June 2017 - September 2017

- **Technical Instruction & Mentorship:** Delivered technical education in a bootcamp setting, guiding students through full-stack coding challenges (Ruby/Rails, JavaScript, React). Utilized live screen-sharing and the Socratic method to build independent problem-solving skills."

Fidelity Payment Services | Integration Specialist & Developer Support | June 2015 - January 2018

- **Developer Enablement & Tooling:** Built internal developer tools and documentation-adjacent web applications to map and track cross-platform compatibility. Raised the quality of technical documentation by translating deep architectural concepts into actionable steps to guide client engineers through complex REST API integrations.

Jewish Online School | Educator | September 2010 - June 2015

- **Curriculum Design & Instruction:** Developed educational materials and delivered remote, highly engaging lessons for a global audience. Specialized in audience retention, student progress tracking, and translating foundational concepts into digestible training formats.

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Technical experience: Java, Go, Kotlin, Ruby/Rails, Python, C++, JavaScript/React/Angular, SQL, Kubernetes.

Engineering Culture & Education: Pair Programming, TDD, CI/CD, Mentorship, Code Review, XP, technical writing, public speaking.

PUBLIC SPEAKING - WRITING

Technical Writing & Blogging:

Author of the active [Rabbi On Rails](https://RabbiOnRails.io) blog where I publish tutorials, overviews, and pontificate on matters related to tech, Judaism, career, ethical AI and more.

Porting Envoy To Windows | KubeCon 2019 - [Video](#) | [Slides](#)

Envoy is an open source edge and service proxy, designed for cloud-native applications. For a half a year I joined Pivotal's effort to contribute a Windows implementation in collaboration with community members at Microsoft, Google, Lyft, and others. In this talk, I, together with my pair William Rowe provided a progress report on where the work was holding, and what still had to be done.

The Algorithm Ate My Homework | RubyConf 2021 - [Video](#)

Am I my algorithm's keeper? Delivered in 2021—a year before the release of ChatGPT—this talk anticipated the ethical complexities of the generative AI revolution. I applied ancient Talmudic liability frameworks to modern engineering questions, exploring the responsibility for autonomous code decisions long before LLMs became ubiquitous. Demonstrated the ability to clearly and logically explain complex, abstract AI concepts to a large technical audience.

Talmudic Gems For Rails Developers | RailsConf 2021 - [Video](#)

More than two thousand years ago, conversations on central questions of human ethics were enshrined in one of the primary ancient wisdom texts, the Talmud. In this talk, I translated a lifetime of Talmudic study and teaching into actionable pedagogical strategies for modern developers, sharing formalized frameworks for pair-programming, technical coaching, technical writing and blogging, and mentoring other budding teachers to help them grow their own educational skills.

Torah & Tech

Weekly Newsletter/Book - [Website](#)

Founded and operated a weekly technical newsletter/community. Translated and synthesized complex discussions on engineering ethics, AI responsibility, and mentorship for a growing audience. Compiled and edited the first year of educational materials into a published printed volume under the name **Torah & Tech; Discussions at the Intersection of Torah and Technology.**